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Professional learning places and spaces: the staffroom as a site of beginning teacher induction and transition

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This paper argues that the staffroom is an important professional learning space where beginning teachers interact to understand who they are and the nature of their professional work. The authors highlight the theoretical importance of space and place in the construction and negotiation of beginning teacher subjectivities. To illustrate the staffroom as a particular place where important professional learning could occur the authors use two narratives based on the lived experiences of two beginning teachers, one in a primary context, the other secondary. The authors conclude by calling for greater research attention to the significance of the staffroom and its interaction with teacher subjectivities. At the level of practice we also call for the teaching profession to recognise staffrooms as important sites of professional learning and places that should support induction and mentoring of beginning teachers. Such recognition could enhance the retention, satisfaction, and effectiveness of new and experienced teachers alike.

Keywords: beginning teachers; place; space; teaching profession

Introduction

As considerable research has indicated, the need for beginning teacher professional induction is unequivocal (Carver & Feiman-Nemser, 2009; Main, 2009; Wang, Odell, & Schwille, 2008; Wiebke & Bardin, 2009). However, as this paper will illustrate, the application of this knowledge to practice in schools is varied, as are the experiences had by those moving from pre-service teacher to fully qualified/licensed teacher. In contrast, there is only modest research into the notion of professional learning spaces and their significance in the induction and transition processes. Becoming a teacher 'requires not only the development of a professional identity but the construction of professional knowledge and practice through continued professional learning' (McCormack, Gore & Thomas, 2006, p. 95). It is this notion of professional learning *space/s* we explore in this paper.

It is widely acknowledged that locations within and beyond schools have been found to function as *spaces* for experienced teachers' workplace learning (McGregor, 2003), however relatively little is known about how the staffroom functions as a professional learning space and how, for new graduates, this affects the process of becoming a teacher. As a *place* we are interested in how the staffroom functions as physical space, but also what might be thought of as social, cultural, and emotional spaces for its occupants. We

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are particularly interested in new teachers within this place as they influence, and are influenced by, professional learning. We acknowledge that two dominant models of staffrooms exist. The first is the lunch-room-cum-meeting room that might be found in a primary setting, where much of teachers' planning, preparation and reflection happens in their own classroom. The second is the secondary department where designated areas around the school are set aside for particular disciplines. The two narratives illustrating this paper reflect one of each but we recognise there are also a number of other models.

Quality teacher professional development clearly has a positive effect on student learning (Hodkinson & Hodkinson, 2005; Louis & Kruse, 1995). However, there is considerable variability across schools in how workplaces sustain these dynamics (Hayes, Mills, Christie, & Lingard, 2006; Talbert & McLaughlin, 2002). The staffroom, the school-based spatial arrangement in which teachers work and/or meet, is an important site for influencing curriculum and resource decisions, a site for the constitution of professional subjectivities (Grosz, 1994) of the pre-service and experienced teacher (Hodkinson & Hodkinson, 2005; McGregor, 2003). It is a social space (Bourdieu, 1985; Lefebvre, 1991) in which certain behaviours, attitudes and dispositions are sanctioned and reinforced while others are perhaps marginalised, dismissed or ridiculed. New teachers are required to read, understand, negotiate, reconstruct, reproduce, resist or reconstitute what is acceptable and what is not within this space. White and Moss (2003) noted the experience for many beginning teachers as one:

> where a silent rage exists. While grappling with issues of professional identity, these teachers have been astounded at both the complexity of teaching and the lack of professionalism within the profession. (p. 8)

In a climate where recruitment and retention of quality teachers is difficult (see for example Liu, Kardos, Kauffman, Preske, & Johnson, 2000; Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development, 2004; Preston, 2000; Ramsay, 2000; Richardson & Watt, 2006), where teacher resignation in challenging schools, often staffed by beginning teachers, is high (Ferfolja, 2008, p. 69), a better understanding of staffroom places would seem to be vital.

Space, time and place

Our orienting questions for the original study that this paper reports included:

- In which spaces does professional learning for beginning teachers occur?
- For those transitioning into schools, are 'staffrooms' spaces for professional learning? If so, then:
  - What is the nature of these spaces?
  - What is learned in these professional spaces?

Lefebvre (1991) conceptualises space in three ways, as physical/material, representational, and, represented. In many school configurations, the teacher's physical place is represented by the teacher's desk and chair in the classroom, and in a designated generalist or specialist place named the staffroom. Representational spaces such as classrooms and staffrooms reify subject positions such as teacher, student, and visitor. Notwithstanding the various configurations of staffrooms, such as the dominant model of primary and secondary staffrooms, the staffroom represents a place where there is potential to learn certain things

that are not likely learned in the classroom or the playground, places where students are present. The staffroom is a potential location for professional learning communities and teacher induction (however informal) to build capacity for sustainability (Stoll, Bolam, McMahon, Wallace, & Thomas, 2006). Accordingly, space is something that is constituted by, and constituting of, groups (Bourdieu, 1985) and the individuals within such groups. Space is therefore at the same time physical and conceptual, constituting and constituted by those in it.

While historically place and space have often been conflated and conceptualised as an area or physical location, like McGregor (2004) and Nespor (1997) we want to emphasise and make explicit the often implied, but not stated, importance of time. We suggest the staffroom is a durable material form, a physical place in which several spaces operate (e.g. professional, social, organisational) and are inextricably and dialogically linked with teacher practices and relations. While we acknowledge Nespor's (2002) argument that places such as the staffroom are not as fixed or bounded as earlier conceptions, for the purposes of this paper the staffroom acts as a focal point for discussion, as an 'intersection or knot in the unique skein of relations' (McGregor, 2004, p. 367). However for us, such a place is also constructed from other times, spaces, relations, processes and practices. Layered upon, or interacting with, this place is a process of transition for new teachers.

The staffroom as a space and place for workplace learning

The literature emphasises the transition time/space between pre-service teacher and experienced teacher as important for the development, positive and negative, of teacher professional identities and its effect on teacher effectiveness and retention (Guarino, Santibañez, & Daley, 2006; Richardson & Watt, 2006). In recognition of this important time/space, substantial efforts and investments in induction and mentoring practices and associated research have been ongoing for more than 20 years (see for example the work of Feiman-Nemser, 1996; Guarino et al., 2006; Kelley, 2004; Odell & Ferraro, 1992; Walkington, 2005). The social practices of transition are played out through both and neither conscious nor unconscious bodies interacting in the spatiality of restrictions, opportunities, and possibilities afforded by multiple social professional spaces (Bourdieu, 1977, 1985), including the staffroom, the classroom and the 'between' spaces/places of lunch breaks, staff meetings, and the like.

Conceptualising transition as a process and/or product of professional spaces allows us to consider that it is not constructed as irreversible, temporally or physically fixed, a single moment, unidirectional, or homogeneously experienced. As such, beginning teachers can be conceptualised as actively participating in such a space, albeit in bounded ways. This is in contrast to the more passive conceptualisation of beginning teachers being socialised or inducted into the subject position of fully credentialed teacher. We will argue that this important space/time of transition intersects with the place of the staffroom as an important site for influencing professional subjectivities. We acknowledge that experienced teachers encountering transfer to new schools will also be affected by place and space but do not explicitly focus on them here. However, we would suggest that our argument is just as relevant for them.

Staffrooms, in their various forms, act as *places*, recognised and named physical spaces that house functional, social, and representational spaces. In keeping with Clandinin and Connelly's (1996), McGregor's (2003) and Nespor's (1997) emphasis on spatiality, we acknowledge the place of the material and the social for workplace learning. While we know a little about how the staffroom functions as a professional culture or community

(Ball & Lacey, 1979; Louis & Kruse, 1995; McLaughlin & Talbert, 2001) that limits, but also unites, groups of teachers (McGregor, 2003, 2004; Paechter, 2004; Talbert, 1995), there is no literature beyond that of our previous work (Rossi, Sirna, & Tinning, 2008; Sirna, Tinning, & Rossi, 2008, 2010) that attends to how this affects the process of becoming a teacher for beginning teachers. McGregor (2004, p. 361) identifies the subject department as 'a stable and critical, if relatively under theorised, feature of secondary schools'. The literature base informing us about staffrooms more generally as a place or space is also very limited.

Studies focussing on induction programs have attempted to tease out how beginning teachers collaboratively make sense of and respond to the micropolitical space of their new workplace (see for example Curry, Jaxon, Russell, Callahan, & Bicais, 2008). In studies such as these, new teachers' 'praxis shock' (Kelchtermans & Ballet, 2002) or 'transition shock' (Corcoran, 1981) was identified as situated in, and negotiated through, relationships but without reference to spatiality. We were interested in providing a thicker description of how such spaces were negotiated by early career teacher subjectivities, and to what extent these subjectivities were constituted or constituting such physical, representative and representational spaces (Lefebvre, 1991).

Methodological back-story

Based upon previous work (Rossi, Sirna, et al., 2008; Sirna et al., 2008, 2010) the current study has traced the experiences of a cohort of early career teachers from their final work placement (school) as an undergraduate and into their first school year as a credentialed probationary professional teacher. Pre-service teachers in their final semester of a teacher education undergraduate degree at an Australian university were asked to participate in the study as interview informants.[1] Semi-structured interviews with the 12 participants who volunteered were recorded, transcribed and analysed thematically. These interviews were conducted: post-practicum/pre-graduation; immediately prior to the school year beginning; within the first few weeks of teaching; towards the end of their first semester, and towards the end of their first year of teaching. Questions were directed towards their feelings and experiences of teaching and in relation to the various spaces in which they were a teacher, including their staffroom. With ethics approval, and participant and gatekeeper written consent, the participants photographed these spaces to act as interview question triggers.

For the purpose of this paper we used sections of their transcripts that referred specifically to being/becoming a teacher, professional learning, and/or the staffroom at the point of transition into the profession. From participant responses and the photographs a number of narratives (Clandinin & Connelly, 2000) were constructed by the researchers, conglomerating similar stories to protect participant identity. These narratives illustrate the nuances and processes in similar experiences of the beginning teachers in this transitional space of graduate to beginning teaching.

This genre of research is said to produce situated knowledge rather than universals and attempts to capture the detail of social life (e.g., through 'slice of life' accounts, Denzin & Lincoln, 2005) rather than abstracting from this detail to produce reductive models. Through two of the narratives we explore how beginning teacher subjectivities might become constructed in workplace relations and in the place of the staffroom. We have chosen the narratives of Sonny and Angel (composite teacher pseudonyms) as they demonstrate the diversity of experience for new teachers. They show how this experience, through the differentiated spaces in different schools, is profound in the development of their teacher

subjectivities. We could have included more narratives but chose to use two only because firstly, we considered that the 'slice of life' accounts, though lengthy and detailed, capture the early experiences in teaching of our cohort. Since our interpretations were checked between researchers we consider that the fidelity between the lived experience and the composite narrative was strong. Secondly, we were mindful that journals necessarily impose restrictions on the length of academic papers. Therefore other tales and individualised accounts will appear under separate covers at subsequent times. At this point, sadly, we can report that there were fewer positive new teacher experiences than there were negative. We would argue this warrants further research.

The narratives are represented below to illustrate the main plot lines (Clandinin & Connelly, 1996) of our participants' experiences. After each narrative we offer an analytical discussion.

Two beginning teacher narratives

Sonny: Itinerant teacher in ambivalent space

Energised and enthusiastic on his first day of being a 'real teacher', Sonny arrives at the rural primary school where he had been appointed as the Physical Education (PE) teacher for three days a week. His other appointment was as a primary classroom generalist to a different school. In anticipation of this momentous day, he had arrived at the school early, waiting in his car until he saw movement in the administration block. While he would not be teaching students today, as it was a student-free day, he was eager to familiarise himself with the school grounds, available resources and importantly his office space, before meeting the other staff at the staff meeting scheduled for 10.00 am. Having collected the school prospectus and timetable for the day, the pleasant administration woman directed him to his office. Key in hand, he carefully followed her directions to a room under the administration block, next to the main staffroom (common/lunch room). As he turned the key and entered the room, his initial sense of excitement waned. Feeling around for the light switch, he was bemused when he thought it was nonexistent. As his eyes adjusted he walked further into the room, scanning his new office space no longer with expectation. His expectations of this space had flown quickly out the only opening of the room, the door. He eventually found a switch behind the plastic storage crates on the shelves – not where he expected. A weak single fluorescent light flickered. In the absence of any natural light Sonny realised this was the best it would be. Shelves holding a mess of sporting equipment and paperwork lined the left-hand side and back walls of the room. On the right-hand side a small bare desk and chair were crammed in beside the table-tennis tables leaning up against the wall. An odd sense of déjà vu overwhelmed him, he had been in a space like this before. . . the realisation hit him. . . the cleaner's cupboard at his old high school.

Sonny was certainly relieved that he had been alone for his initial visit to his office space. While he was somewhat surprised and taken aback with the cupboard-like appearance and limited lighting, he reasoned that he was lucky to have his own office space at all. Having completed his major practicum in a high school and spent irregular and intermittent periods of time in primary schools throughout his undergraduate degree, Sonny didn't really know what to expect of the primary school setting nor could he recall the primary specialist PE teachers having or using an office space. While his preference was to work as a primary school specialist PE teacher, his lack of familiarity within a primary school context was disconcerting.

Being the sole PE teacher at the school, Sonny was responsible for all PE lessons for all year levels, all the intra-school (tournaments and lunchtime sport) and inter-school

sport organisation. Sonny was astonished that he had received no advice or direction in relation to his duties as the specialist PE teacher in his first few days at the school, nor had he been allocated a mentor or received any information about an induction program. Being proactive he sought out the deputy principal who vaguely directed him to some paperwork left by the previous PE teacher. The paperwork was sketchy, containing rough, mostly incomplete unit plans, event programs and a few contact numbers for district sport. Initially frustrated and overwhelmed with the amount of work and with what appeared to Sonny as a serious lack of support, he started organising the upcoming swimming gala and reworked the PE program. While Sonny had an understanding that his initial experience and first term would have been far easier with guidance and support, he revelled in the fact that he could navigate this new context with some, if not a large amount of, anonymity and autonomy.

When Sonny wasn't on playground duty or running lunchtime sport, a rare event, he enjoyed visiting the common 'staffroom' for lunch. It was in these infrequent visits to this space that he befriended the other school specialist teachers from music and LOTE.[2] While Sonny felt quite independent in his development as a PE teacher, the little time spent with other specialist teachers provided reassurance and aided his understanding of what it meant to be a specialist teacher in this very particular context. Sonny was always pleased when his sporadic visits to the staffroom for lunch corresponded with the other specialist teachers' inconsistent visits because he could let his guard down, ask questions and experience a sense of belonging. Generalist classroom teachers would wander in but usually clustered together in their year-level groupings, otherwise lunching in their classrooms. Sonny's interaction with the generalist teachers was professional and structured, typically occurring when they collected or delivered their classes or during intra-school and inter-school sport.

As the first term progressed Sonny was pleasantly surprised that with such a high teaching load he had limited opportunity and time in his day to spend in his office, which, given that it doubled as the storage cupboard, was not difficult. He organised a lamp to supplement the inadequate light and a fan, however Sonny did not generally work there. Through a bit of detective work he had found a communal computer and printer in the common staffroom which he accessed during and after school hours, a much-preferred space to his dimly lit and musty office. As the other teachers had computers in their classrooms the common staffroom space was quiet and conducive to work early in the mornings and late after school, the only time Sonny had time for planning and organisation.

Professional space: voids and isolation

Issues of school culture and teachers' personal and professional histories have emerged as strong mediating influences in determining the kinds and stability of professional subjectivities that teachers develop in their early professional lives (Flores & Day, 2006). For Sonny, who was rather like an itinerant teacher in his own school, the times where general classroom teachers were timetabled to be 'off class' were either while he was taking their class for PE or during meal breaks where he was often involved in sports coaching. Although the policy of providing classroom teachers with 'non contact time' was seen to be a positive move for them, there has been no consideration as to the impact this has on the 'specialist' who provides learning experiences for students in this time. In many instances the itinerant space of specialist teachers in primary schools means there is no time or space available for them to communicate, collaborate or participate in professional exchanges with other teachers.

The itinerant teacher model is in stark contrast with that of a secondary subject department where many opportunities for 'casual, serendipitous contact as well as more focused social

or work-related conversations' were provided (McGregor, 2003, p. 54). Notwithstanding the problems associated with treating subject departments as silos (Macdonald, 2003; Talbert, 1995), the advantages around communities of professional practice stand out. In Sonny's case such a community is missing, as is one based upon the broader notion of collegiality discussed as important to teacher professional subjectivities formation (see for example McGregor, 2003).

Neither induction nor mentoring was offered to Sonny and although he expressed satisfaction with teaching and an appreciation of autonomy he also felt professional feedback and interaction to be lacking. Kelley (2004) has shown positive results in the long-term retention and effectiveness of novice teachers who participated in an induction partnership between the teacher education institution and schools. While induction does not necessarily mean there will be capacity building in the teacher profession, some models showing little if any effect, we are left to wonder what the lack of a good induction program might mean for teachers such as Sonny who also lacks the collegiality and conversations suggested in the literature as necessary for the development of teacher subjectivities.

Physical space – ambivalence of the subject

Numerous studies (e.g. Kim & Taggart, 2004; Paechter & Head, 1996; Thompson, 2003) illustrate the ambivalent or low status in which physical education is held in the school system. For Sonny, the ambivalence of the school system towards PE is also reflected in the ambivalent professional spaces made available to him. The poorly lit storage room did not match the desk and classroom space of the generalist teachers and required him to relocate to do some of the procedural or planning tasks of a teacher, such as those needing computer use. The temporal space where teachers *did* congregate in the central staffroom was often not available to Sonny as his coaching and sports team management work occurred at these times. Even the temporal space allocated for generalist teachers to plan did not include Sonny as this was precisely the time allocated for him to teach.

Angel: At 'home' with the 'staffroom' family

Angel experienced nothing but guidance and professional support from the moment she received her first teaching position at a Rural Catholic College. While at times overwhelming, the busy and chaotic transition into the school, and ultimately her teaching career, was smooth, facilitated by an induction morning devoted exclusively to beginning graduate teachers and new teachers to the school. It was on this morning that she was introduced to the school's administration team, the heads of departments and importantly her mentor, a female PE teacher with three years' experience. The induction provided an opportunity for Angel to receive information about the school's policies, procedures and expectations. Angel felt very valued and welcomed, thankful for the opportunity to ease into starting and to gain a clear understanding of expectations of her by the school in professional standards (e.g. dress, extra-curricular commitments, resource sharing and development) and professional development.

Angel and her housemate, Mandy, also a beginning teacher at the school, had met some of the teachers at a barbecue they been invited to prior to their induction. This, coupled with Mandy being by her side today, offered Angel confidence as she entered the staffroom for the first time, meeting and greeting the other teachers on staff. Housing all the staff from all subject areas, the staffroom space is long and narrow, a corridor-like room with benches running the length of the walls. Each teacher, mostly female, is allocated

one and a half metres of bench space and corresponding storage space directly overhead where shelves contour the walls. This space allocation is more than enough for Angel, but for some teachers it is an obvious challenge to keep their stacked folders of units and resources within their allocated space without spilling into others' space. Some teachers own their laptops and have them on their desks, however Angel makes use of one of the six communal computers at one end of the staffroom. Apart from peak times, before and after school, gaining access to a computer is unproblematic. Similarly, resources such as unit plans, lesson plans and worksheets are very accessible in this communal space. The reworking of, addition to, and sharing of resources is explicitly encouraged, a value clearly immersed within the staffroom context across all subject areas. To Angel, the physical layout of the space embodies and encapsulates this strong sense of openness, cooperation and collaboration between teachers, regardless of teaching areas, giving access to an invaluable resource, other teachers.

Like the other teachers, when Angel is not teaching or on playground duty, she is hanging out or working in the staffroom. She affectionately likens the staffroom to a safe place, a home or haven at school away from the students. At times, a fun relaxed atmosphere permeates the staffroom, everyone being silly and filling the room with laughter. This inclusive social atmosphere transfers beyond school hours to social gatherings and staff functions on weekends. In times of work, Angel experiences a sense of togetherness and belonging through the continual questioning and inquiries about her progress and teaching, not only from her heads of department and mentor but also other staff. Their selfless time giving, answering questions and general concern for her development as a beginning teacher, is clearly evident. These feelings of being immersed in the staffroom and the school are in stark comparison to her practicum experience where she felt insignificant and transient. As a beginning teacher she is now privy to the behind-the-scenes happenings of the school, more able to effectively engage with relevant information about students, teaching and the school. Similarly her access to support and development of comfortable, stable professional relationships signify the disparity between Angel's experience of now being a teacher and that of a pre-service teacher the year before. As the semester progresses the induction and mentoring process is complemented with beginning teacher meetings scheduled every fortnight and the sharing of a homeroom class with an experienced teacher.

Smooth transitional professional space in place: induction, scaffolding and mentoring

Unlike the initial confusion and anxiety experienced by many novice teachers (Tickle, 1994, 2000), including Sonny in our first story, Angel experienced a strong sense of openness, support and cooperation within her staffroom and with her staff. Young (2000) argues that new teachers not only need to become experts in the technical aspects of teaching, but also to develop the professional capacity to deal with conflicts developing between their personal and professional lives. Angel was provided many opportunities for this, within and beyond the staffroom. Although assigned a mentor and given a specific induction to the school, she quickly identified individuals who could help answer her specific questions, those who were easily accessible in the mixed-subject and common staffroom and with whom she had met through the induction day, in-service days, staffroom functions, and social functions outside the school. The physical staffroom was cohesive, open, and included all teachers other than the administration. The physical space reflected how Angel felt in relation to the staff and moved beyond the materiality of the place as she maintained her teacher subjectivities in other places in the town, evidenced when participating in the staff netball weekend team and weekend staff trips.

The literature supports mentoring and induction programs to facilitate the transition from pre-service to credentialed teacher and to transmit the culture of the system to the new teacher (Huling-Austin, 1990; McCulla, 2005; Smith & Ingersoll, 2004). For Angel this mentoring took place in the staffroom but was not confined to the staffroom, supporting Nespor's (2002) notion that the functions of specialised spaces are often not as bounded as perhaps they are represented. Nevertheless, in this case the staffroom was a significant space for the new teacher to collaborate and interact in professional exchanges as well as bond or connect with other staff. This reinforces the finding of McCormack et al. (2006) that while formal induction programs and mentoring are useful, 'collaborative, informal, unplanned learning from colleagues and former peers was also reported as a most significant and valuable source of support' (p. 95). Angel felt very comfortable with the challenges of being a beginning teacher as her needs for professional contact were met with positive relationships. She was scaffolded in terms of the necessary information to understand expectations of her by others and what she could expect of colleagues and students. For Angel, the staffroom was a central place where all teachers were physically located regardless of their specialist subject areas. This place also linked with other spaces where the social relations were reinforced despite relocation. This included staff social events within and beyond the school and indicated strength of relations that were not only constructed with and within the place of the staffroom but endured relocation.

Where do the stories leave us?

While supportive and affirming induction and mentoring practices clearly exist in experiences such as Angel's, and are shown to be important in teacher professional development and retention, their implementation seems to be 'patchy' at best (McCulla, 2005, p. 37). As a profession wishing to attract quality practitioners and hold a more respected status within society, we (the teaching profession) must ask ourselves to what extent we expect and practise the creation of supportive and affirming professional workplaces for new teachers. How might the staffroom (general or subject specific), a distinctive space where professional culture and power relations are practised, facilitate or resist different forms of social space that make possible the teacher subjectivities needed to transform student learning? Stoll et al. (2006) suggest that advancing professional spaces through professional learning communities seems to hold promise for capacity building for sustainable development although not without cautions.

Kelley's (2004) work demonstrates that induction does indeed matter, that a meaningful induction experience has lasting effects on teacher quality and retention. However, Feiman-Nemser (1996) makes the point that for beginning teachers to learn the ways of thinking and acting associated with new kinds of teaching, they need to be placed with mentors who are already reformers in their classrooms or schools and develop collaborative environments. Conceptualising the staffroom not just as a physical space but also an opportunistic professional learning space that is perhaps underutilised or under-represented or even (if inadvertently) totally absent may provide a more useable platform for analysis. Given 'schools that provided mentoring and induction programs, particularly those related to collegial support, had lower rates of turnover among beginning teachers' (Guarino et al., 2006, p. 201), we could imagine a more productive staffroom and staff for those in Sonny's situation (and that of others in the study) if the space were to be conceptualised as a learning space and not just somewhere to 'dump your gear'. While Angel's situation seemed more akin to a positive experience, our ongoing research that tracks each of these teachers will help us understand better the

complexities of the outcomes of induction, mentoring and professional spaces for new teachers.

Interrelationship between places and spatiality in teachers' work/learning

The work of Clandinin and her colleagues (Clandinin & Connelly, 1996; Clandinin, Downey, & Huber, 2009), McGregor (2003, 2004), Nespor (1997, 2002), and Paechter (2004) provides a useful conceptual background upon which to continue to think about the interrelationship of professional spaces, physical places, power, subjectivities and relationships in conjunction with the transitional membership space for beginning teachers. While each of these authors has attempted to provide stronger theorisation around such a space we would argue that there is still only very limited theorisation and research about the spatiality of teachers' work. The importance of, and interplay between, the school structures and cultures in new teachers' beginning in the workplace should not be underestimated if teacher retention or the development of professional learning and professional cultures is of any significance.

The ability of new teachers and beginning teachers to read the social spaces presented to them when entering a new situation affords them greater capacity to be able to position them within that space. For Angel, the subject position of teacher was consistent and seamless across spaces so her negotiation of these spaces was relatively smooth compared to that of Sonny. While the physical/material places were important in symbolic value and the opportunities they afforded, the interrelationships within those spaces was still a critical factor in the experiences of beginning teachers. Drawing on Lefebvre (1991), Kostogriz and Peeler (2007) refer to this as orientation in social space or a deciphering of produced space. This is 'an ability to navigate-perceive, decode and make sense of or "read" different locations and places that have been historically produced and have acquired cultural-semiotic meanings' (p. 109). It is clear to us there is an important question to ask of the teacher education process. Just how well are pre-service teachers prepared to be able to orient themselves successfully in new spaces and more clearly participate in those practices that shape the subjectivities needed for a more effective educational system? How *different* spaces might be negotiated by *different* new teachers also needs further investigation to build on the work of Ferfolja (2008) and Kostogriz and Peeler (2007), among others.

Finally, there is much scope for further discussion and research around the conceptualisation of the practices, the processes and products, of what has previously been 'metaphored' as transition, induction, transformation, socialisation, enculturation and probation. Other metaphors such as migration, mobilisation, circulation, and co-construction to describe what happens in the space between the pre-service teacher and the fully credentialed teacher might offer us greater insights into 'becoming a teacher' and being an agent of change through teaching. This is to enhance not only the educational experiences of young people in our schools but also the profession and the professional.

Conclusion

Through two narratives, this paper has highlighted the theoretical importance of a notion of space and place in the construction and negotiation of beginning teacher subjectivities. With a focus on the staffroom as a particular place where important professional learning could occur we used the narratives to illustrate lived experiences of two beginning teachers. In the current climate of concern surrounding teacher induction, retention and effectiveness, their stories highlight some of the issues for beginning teachers including the importance

of the staffroom as a potential professional learning space and the importance of space and time for professional development. The quality and nature of the staffroom could act as a barometric site of our profession and professional strength and self-esteem. Our research implications relating to induction and mentoring of new teachers include paying attention to what might count as acceptable workplaces. This touches on a broader issue about what is acceptable as a workplace, extending to all staff in schools be they new or not. Some of the physical, social and emotional spaces within schools would seem to be unacceptable for teachers to be able to carry out their work successfully, the theme of our more recent work (lisahunter & Flanagan, 2010; lisahunter, Rossi, Flanagan, Tinning, & Macdonald, 2010; lisahunter, Rossi, Tinning, & Flanagan, 2009; Rossi, lisahunter, Tinning, & Macdonald, 2008). For teacher educators and practitioners, our research also points to considerations such as highlighting and exploring the professional space/s and places of pre-service and beginning teachers and the implications for reading and responding to such places in particular ways. Our research also suggests that those charged with pre-service workplace practice must ensure that the places and spaces available to pre-service teachers are adequate for them to carry out their work requirements. Those spaces that cannot do so must be regarded as unacceptable. We argue that further research into: the staffroom and its links to other professional learning spaces; professional spaces of induction and mentoring for pre-service and beginning teachers; the adequacy of workplaces for teachers to carry out their work; and the interaction between place and beginning teachers is crucial.

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Notes

1. Ethical approval was granted by The Ethics Committee of the University. All participants gave their consent for involvement and publication of de-identified data. Pseudonyms were used in this paper.
2. LOTE or Language Other Than English is a key learning area in the state-based syllabus suite of documents developed for primary schools. Teachers of LOTE are most often specialist teachers of a particular language.

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